

ROBERTA SANTIAGO

Senior Product Designer · UX/UI · Design Systems

Novara, Italy (Piedmont, 50 km from Milan) · Italian residence with full work rights · Open to on-site, hybrid, remote and relocation
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PROFILE

Senior product designer with nine years across fintech, carbon offsetting, broadcast media, automation and AI products. I work where product strategy meets system structure: research, information architecture, service and data modelling, permission models for multi-role products, end-to-end flows, high-fidelity UI, and the design systems that hold it all together. I founded and run my own studio, so I have owned products from first conversation to shipped release, including the commercial and engineering trade-offs in between.

Most of my recent work is AI-shaped, where the design question is which judgements the system may make on its own and which it has to hand back to a person. Formal background in systems analysis and university research in accessibility. I write about the theory behind the craft: three books, on interface design, on innovation strategy and on digitalisation, each published in Portuguese and English. Native Portuguese, C1 English used daily in work, Italian improving.

I am looking for a product team whose working language is English, in Europe, across the Atlantic, or fully distributed, where design is treated as a strategic function rather than a rendering service. I hold an Italian residence permit with full work rights, so any role based in Italy, on-site, hybrid or remote, can start without paperwork. Remote is one option rather than a requirement: I work well in an office, and I am open to relocating for the right team.

EXPERIENCE

Founder & Lead Product Designer · Kolabs

Dec 2018 – Present · Curitiba, Brazil → Italy

- Founded and run an independent product design studio. Since 2018, leading UX strategy and UI across fintech, carbon offsetting, field-operations, media and SaaS platforms.
- Own the full arc on client work: discovery and user research, information architecture, system modelling (UML, flows, use cases), end-to-end flows, high-fidelity interfaces, and hand-off through to release.
- Build and maintain design systems and component libraries, including a fully documented system for Next Day (foundations, components, roles, motion, voice) used as the single source of truth by engineering.
- Design and ship a React and TypeScript codebase with two engineers, setting the standard that AI-generated code has to meet before it ships. I prototype in code myself when a working artifact answers a question faster than a mockup.
- Partner directly with engineering on technical feasibility and UX quality, and align founders, developers and commercial goals across concurrent projects.

Selected work: Carbono Neutro (carbon-credit exchange, four distinct user personas), Next Day (ephemeral B2B2C event network, iOS), Luckify (white-label raffle SaaS, where I also built the Figma plugin the team designs with), FlexScan (algorithmic trading automation), B.House (offline-first building inspection), GeoBot, now respond.io (WhatsApp campaign automation), RIC TV (second-screen app for live television audiences).

Customer Success Manager · Ateliware

Jan 2017 – Aug 2017 · Curitiba, Brazil

- Gathered structured feedback from 300+ active clients and turned it into prioritised UX improvements.
- Identified usability issues and product gaps through direct customer contact, and fed them back into the roadmap.
- Supported QA by reporting defects and validating fixes from the user's perspective.

RESEARCH

Student Researcher, Smart Corridor · GEPTA Research Group, Federal University of Paraná

2015 – 2016 · Curitiba, Brazil

An intelligent access-control device for pedestrian flow, designed for accessibility through audiovisual guidance for visually and hearing-impaired users. I contributed to methodology definition, analysis of sensor and automation technologies, and validation of user access during implementation. Supervised by Prof. Dr. Luiz Antônio Pereira Neves.
gepta.weebly.com/smart-corridor.html

WRITING

- Teoria do Design / Design Theory: a practitioner's book on interface design. Semiotics, Gestalt, perspective, optical distortion, iconisation, diegetic interfaces, UI typography, and a 2026 chapter on accessibility covering WCAG 2.1 AA and the European Accessibility Act. Nine chapters, 143 illustrations, Portuguese and English.
- Empresas do futuro / Companies of the Future: twelve chapters on innovation strategy, process design and digitalisation for business owners. Portuguese and English.
- Simplificando a digitalização / Simplifying Digitalisation: five sections on why software designed around function fails to hold people, and what immersion changes. Portuguese and English.

SKILLS

Design: UX research (qualitative and quantitative) · Information architecture · Interaction design · Service and system modelling (UML, flows, use cases) · Design systems · Usability testing and validation · Gamification and behavioural design · Product strategy

Delivery: Figma (advanced, including plugin development) · HTML / CSS / JavaScript · Prototyping · Analytics and A/B testing · Accessibility to WCAG 2.1 AA and EN 301 549

Languages: Portuguese (native) · English (C1, advanced) · Italian (A2, improving)

EDUCATION

Federal University of Paraná (UFPR), Curitiba, Brazil

Systems Analysis & Development · coursework, 2016 to 2020. No degree conferred.

Product Design · two and a half years of coursework, 2012 to 2015. No degree conferred.

Universidade Positivo, Curitiba, Brazil

Systems Analysis & Development, BSc · coursework, 2024 to 2025. No degree conferred.